The Water Cycle

Every drop of water on Earth has a long history. The water you drink today may once have been part of a cloud, a river, or a glacier. Earth does not make new water or lose much of its old water. Instead, the same water travels again and again between the oceans, the air, the land, and living things.

Evaporation

Evaporation is the change of liquid water into water vapor. When the Sun warms the surface of an ocean, a lake, or a puddle, the fastest water molecules escape into the air as an invisible gas. Warm temperatures, wind and dry air all speed it up.

Condensation

As warm, moist air rises it cools, and the vapor changes back into tiny drops of liquid water. Billions of these drops together make a cloud.

Precipitation

When cloud droplets grow too heavy they fall as rain, snow, sleet or hail. Water that reaches the ground is collected in rivers, lakes, oceans, soil and ice, and the cycle begins again.